



QUESTIONS AND ANSWERS

Combat Mindset Framework Proposal

PREPARATION FOR THE COMDT ACS DISCUSSION

New Zealand Army Leadership Centre | Army Command School

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1. How to Open

The discussion is less likely to be about whether Combat Mindset matters and more about whether the proposed construct is clear, ownable and executable. The paper asks COMDT ACS to make four foundational decisions: endorse the problem, choose the relationship between Combat Mindset and Performance Under Pressure, accept the definitions as a drafting baseline, and authorise the programme of work.

Open from the Model on a Page (page 3) rather than from the written paper. It is the handrail for the whole conversation: warfighting imperative, enabling capability, organising system, five-step development programme. Tell the story in four lines, then stop and let COMDT challenge it.

Combat Mindset is the warfighting outcome we care about.
Performance Under Pressure is the trainable capability underneath it.
The Framework is how Army organises it.
The five phases are how we propose to build that system.

2. The Decision Sought

Be ready to answer "what do you actually need from me today?" in twenty seconds.

Sir, we need four things today. First, agreement that the problem is a lack of coherence and ownership rather than a lack of activity. Second, agreement that Performance Under Pressure is the enabling capability and Combat Mindset its combat-specific expression. Third, permission to use these definitions as our drafting baseline, not final doctrine. And fourth, authority to commence the five-phase programme.

That reflects the paper's own framing: today's decisions establish the drafting baseline and the authority to commence. Final doctrine, governance and implementation arrangements remain subject to Army approval processes (Purpose; Recommendations 1 to 5).

3. Likely Questions

Q1. Why do we need two terms? Why not call the whole thing Combat Mindset?

This is probably the first question. Option 1 creates a hierarchy, and the paper itself concedes that soldiers already use Combat Mindset as the umbrella term (section 2, Option 2 advantages).

Performance Under Pressure is the trainable human-performance capability. Combat Mindset is what that capability looks like when applied to the particular demands of combat. The Framework is simply the Army system that governs and develops both.

- The distinction matters because Performance Under Pressure stays applicable to command, crisis response, garrison leadership and high-risk technical activity, where there is pressure but not necessarily an enemy (Option 1 advantages).
- Option 2's own limitations are the answer to "why not one term": it conflates the combat outcome with the broader capability, makes doctrine, capability, framework and product hard to tell apart, and raises the risk that Combat Mindset is read as motivation or aggression alone.
- Concede the cost honestly: two terms must be explained and sustained in doctrine, instruction and everyday use (Option 1 limitation). That is a communication task, not a design flaw.

Q2. What exactly is the problem we are trying to solve?

COMDT may push away from the conceptual model and ask what is actually broken. The paper's answer is strong: Army already has substantial capability; the deficiency is coherence, visibility, common terminology, ownership and assurance, not an absence of training content (section 1). This is the most important message to land.

Sir, we are not proposing another training product. We are proposing an organising framework for a lot of good activity Army already does, but does not yet coherently own, describe or assure.

- The underlying operational problem is unchanged: under operational pressure, trained individuals and teams do not always retain access to their full capability.
- COMDT's own guidance of 16 July 2026 reached the same diagnosis. Quote it if needed.

Q3. Who owns this?

Expect this early. The paper deliberately does not prejudge the enduring answer: Phase 1 establishes interim sponsorship, programme leadership, phase leads and decision authorities, while the programme determines enduring capability ownership, technical authority and assurance (section 4, Phase 1). COMDT may still want a name.

ACS sponsors. NZALC leads the framework development. HPC leads the human-performance technical contribution. APS, ILD and the training establishments are stakeholders and technical contributors. Enduring ownership is an output of the work, not something this paper should settle today.

Q4. Is NZALC trying to own Combat Mindset?

Related to Q3 but politically different. Because the NZALC Leadership Development System features prominently in section 3, the paper could be read as NZALC building an umbrella around its own material. The answer is an emphatic no.

The framework has to sit above individual products and organisations. NZALC is leading the work, but we are deliberately preventing LDS, COGCON or any other existing product from becoming the framework by default.

- The paper says this in terms: existing products, including the NZALC Leadership Development System and COGCON, will be mapped against the endorsed outcomes and framework requirements rather than treated as the framework itself (Phase 3).

Q5. Where does COGCON fit?

Expect this if HPC are in the room. The answer is that we do not yet know, and that is deliberate. Do not be drawn into defending or dismissing it.

COGCON is one potentially useful product within the system. Phase 2 assesses what it actually delivers, the strength of its evidence, who should own it and whether it can scale.

- The paper's position (section 3): a developmental cognitive-conditioning product with acceptability and promising training trends from feasibility trials; causal effectiveness, operational transfer, readiness validity, scalability and the enduring delivery model not yet established; status and future role confirmed through Phase 2.

Q6. How is this different from resilience, mental skills, leadership or psychology?

The paper guards against Combat Mindset becoming synonymous with aggression, motivation or resilience alone (Option 1 advantages). Broaden that slightly.

Those are contributors. None of them individually constitutes Combat Mindset. The framework gives Army a way of saying which human-performance capabilities contribute to effective performance under combat pressure, and how they fit together.

Q7. What makes something Combat Mindset rather than good human-performance training?

The combat-specificity test in section 2 is the answer: opposition or threat, significant mission or human consequence, and ethical load. A product is combat-specific where it develops or applies Performance Under Pressure in a context that represents or deliberately simulates those demands. Expect COMDT to test it with examples.

Example	Answer
Is a breathing technique Combat Mindset?	No, not inherently. It is a Performance Under Pressure technique.
Is using that technique while making a difficult tactical decision under realistic threat and consequence Combat Mindset?	Yes. That is the combat-specific application.
Is a garrison leadership course Combat Mindset?	It contributes to the enabling capability. It becomes combat-specific only where it represents the defining demands.

Q8. What do I actually get at the end of November?

An important command question. Not another discussion paper.

By the end, you should be able to see what Army is trying to develop in its people, what products contribute to it, where those products sit across the developmental continuum, who owns what, and how Army knows whether those products are effective.

- In the paper's terms: Framework v1.0 comprising developmental outcomes from Lead Self through Lead Systems, product architecture, governance arrangements and assurance criteria (Phase 3), validated with stakeholders (Phase 4), and submitted with a governance and assurance model, an implementation plan and a back brief (Phase 5).

Q9. Are these timelines realistic?

Potentially uncomfortable: September is now, and the paper proposes Define and Understand in September, Design in October, Validate in November and Implement in late November. The paper calls the timelines aspirational and anticipates work extending into early 2027 (Recommendation 5). Do not overpromise.

The sequence matters more than the dates. We can move quickly because considerable work already exists, but we do not want schedule pressure to manufacture consensus or lock in doctrine prematurely.

Q10. Who needs to be involved?

The paper lists ACS, NZALC, HPC, APS, ILD, training establishments and selected units (Phases 2 and 4). The point to make is that this cannot become an ACS-only intellectual exercise.

Units validate whether it makes operational sense. The professional and technical stakeholders validate whether it is evidence-based and supportable. We need both.

Q11. How will we know whether any of this works?

Possibly the hardest substantive question. The paper has not predetermined the measurement model; Phase 3 identifies how progression, transfer to performance, product quality and organisational adoption will be assessed. Offer three levels so that success does not collapse into "soldiers completed Combat Mindset training".

Level	The question it answers
Individual and team	Can people actually perform better under pressure?
Product	Does the intervention produce the outcome it claims?
System	Is Army consistently developing, delivering and assuring the capability?

Q12. What decision do you need from me today?

See section 2. Four things, in twenty seconds.

4. The Three Areas to Prepare Hardest

1. **Terminology.** Explain Performance Under Pressure, Combat Mindset and the Framework without sounding theoretical. Use the breathing-technique example from Q7.
2. **Ownership.** Hold a crisp interim position on who leads now, while making clear that enduring governance is part of the work.
3. **Tangible output.** Be able to say what changes for a soldier, a commander and the Army institution once the framework exists.

5. Facts to Have to Hand

Item	Detail
Direction	COMDT ACS, 16 July 2026: NZALC with HPC to develop a strategy to close the Combat Mindset policy and doctrine gap
Recommended option	Option 1: Combat Mindset as the combat-specific expression of Performance Under Pressure. Jointly recommended by NZALC and HPC; both options deliver the COMDT end state
Combat Mindset	The individual and collective readiness and disposition to remain effective and act decisively and ethically under the threat, adversity and uncertainty of combat in order to achieve the mission
Performance Under Pressure	The trainable individual and collective human-performance capability to prepare for, maintain effective performance through, adapt within and recover from conditions that create significant physiological, cognitive, emotional or social interference
Combat Mindset Framework	The framework through which Army governs, develops, delivers and assures Performance Under Pressure and its combat-specific expression
Combat-specificity test	Opposition or threat; significant mission or human consequence; ethical load
Phases	1 Define (Sep 26), 2 Understand (Sep 26), 3 Design (Oct 26), 4 Validate (Nov 26), 5 Implement (late Nov 26); aspirational, may extend into early 2027
Stakeholders	ACS, NZALC, HPC, APS, ILD, training establishments, selected units
Recommendations	Endorse the problem; approve the relationship; endorse the working definitions as the drafting baseline; approve commencement; note the timeframes are aspirational